CHAPTER THREE:
ARMORED ENEMIES

A hero is only as good as his villains…isn't he? Like many of Marvel's heroes, Iron Man's biggest demons have often been internal—from Tony Stark's heart problems to his alcoholism, the comic book version of the character has often had more memorable moments fighting with himself or his friends, than grand archenemies.

The makers of Iron Man 2 were only too aware of this potential pitfall. "Iron Man does not have the deepest bench when it comes to villains," Co-Producer Jeremy Latcham says by way of a sports analogy. "Tony Stark does not necessarily have this iconic, obvious villain that feels convincing. The Mandarin's the closest thing you get." But the mystically powered Mandarin didn't seem to be a good fit for the more technologically oriented film.

Latcham continues, "In prep we had a giant wall with all the great villains from Iron Man's world hung on it, and there was not a villain that jumped out a hundred percent as this is 'the guy.' But we started looking at Crimson Dynamo, who had this backstory that had some intrigue. But in the first film, Tony Stark fought a guy in a metal suit and we thought, 'We don't really want him to fight another guy in a metal suit again.' So we started looking at the Crimson Dynamo backstory and kind of playing with some other characters, and we really liked Whiplash."

Finally, another piece fell into place. "One of the things we really wanted to play with was this theme of 'legacy,' and really play with Tony's father," says Latcham. "In the first film, Tony said, 'There's a couple of things I would have asked my dad if I had the chance.' We really wanted Tony to explore his dad. And we thought it would be cool if his dad was not entirely the black-and-white version of the best character in the world, but his dad probably was involved in some heavy stuff back in the day."

As the history of Howard Stark merged with the backstory of Whiplash, the story took form.

